quickly. On approval, this would be the first vaccine in the world to be accepted under the DNA plasmid technology platform, a rather proud first step for India.

Gennova, an Indian company, had also reached advanced stages in the development of their mRNA-based vaccine. If successful, it would be India's first indigenous mRNA vaccine, further reducing our dependence on international manufacturers.

In a conversation, Mr Sanjay Singh, CEO of Gennova, had said to me, 'I had written my first email to the GoI regarding Gennova's efforts to create an mRNA vaccine in March 2020. Immediately after, the GoI asked us to show proof of concept and once we were able to demonstrate reasonable success, we were given ₹25 crore as seed funds to buy machinery and raw material.'

**12 AUGUST 2020**

INDIA | 6,52,127 ACTIVE CASES | 47,484 DEATHS

WORLD | 57,15,499 ACTIVE CASES | 8,32,376 DEATHS

Considering that by now there was significant visibility on the availability of vaccines, a new group called the National Expert Group on Vaccine Administration for COVID-19 (NEGVAC) was constituted with Dr Paul and secretary of MoHFW as co-chairs. Members included representatives from five state governments: UP, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh and Assam, representatives from AIIMS, technical experts, representatives from the National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation, secretaries from the Ministry of External Affairs, Department of Expenditure, Department of Biotechnology, Department of Health Research, Department of Pharmaceuticals, and the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology. Essentially, NEGVAC was constituted in order to find solutions for vaccination implementation on a large scale. They'd go on to decide priority groups, when to open up vaccination for the younger individuals, make protocols on which comorbidities would be considered for eligibility in priority groups, provide solutions for cold chain logistics for vaccine deliveries and ensure availability of associated medical equipment required like syringes, needles